

AREC 570/ECON 530 Syllabus Fall 2026

Course Information:

Course Title: Methodology of Economic Research

Meeting: TR 8:00 – 9:15 AM

Location: Natural Resources 108

Instructor: Dr. Amanda Countryman

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Office Hours: Tuesdays 9:30-10:30am or by appointment

Instructor: Dr. Lauren Chenarides

Phone: 970-491-2480

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Office Hours: By appointment ([meeting link](#) or via email)

Course Description: We will study the philosophical foundations of science and research with particular emphasis on the field of economics. You will develop skills for planning, performing, reporting, and evaluating economic research. Our goal with this course is to make you think critically about the research process. As is the case with most subjects, students tend to learn best by putting the concepts into practice. We will read about research methodology. You will then analyze the logic and reasoning of other's research as well as develop your own research proposal.

Course Materials:

All readings will be shared through OneDrive and Canvas.

Course Website: Canvas will serve as the portal for accessing course materials. Readings, class schedule, and other material will be posted in Canvas. An additional, external course website built on GitHub will contain some course materials and will be linked directly from the Canvas page.

Course Expectations: You are expected to check Canvas and your CSU email regularly for course-related information, readings, and possibly assignments. Replies and correspondence will only be sent to your university email addresses or Canvas. We can best be reached by email. When many students have the same kind of question, we may reply to the entire class or post announcements to the course website.

Proposal: You will write and revise a research proposal on a topic of your choice. You may select a research topic you are already using for another class. In fact, we recommend using this class to deepen your engagement with your research. Ideally, the research proposal will be a chapter in your dissertation or a foundation for your thesis. The research proposal will be separated into multiple parts so that we can provide feedback throughout the proposal.

Proposal Structure:

- **Part 1 Research Idea Pitch:** 3-minute presentation of the research idea
- **Part 2 Research Question and Outline:** develop a clear and appropriate research question; outline the paper/proposal
- **Part 3 Introduction and Literature Review:** draft of the introduction and literature review for your project proposal
- **Part 4 First Draft:** complete the first draft of the proposal containing all required sections
- **Part 5 Review:** write a formal review of a classmate's proposal.
- **Part 6 Proposal Presentation:** 15-minute presentation of research findings

- **Part 7 Final Draft:** complete the final draft of the proposal including a formal response to the reviewer

Participation: You are expected to read the assigned material, participate in discussions during class meetings, and complete any additional assignments. We will assign a TBD number of short writing assignments. The writing assignments will ask you to apply the techniques discussed in class to analyze some aspects of the research process. We will also assign someone to prepare discussion questions and lead the class discussion for a select number of reading assignments.

Course Outline and Content:

- Research Methodology Foundations
- Research Project Design
 - Planning a project
 - Developing Economic Research Questions
- The Writing Process:
 - Introduction
 - Literature Review
 - Theory
 - Data
 - Empirical Model
 - Conclusion
- Other Aspects of Research:
 - Presenting
 - Selecting an Outlet or Funding Opportunity
 - Reviewing Research and Responding to Reviews
 - Ethics in Research (Institutional Review Board)

Please refer to the tentative class schedule at the end of the syllabus.

Grading:

Participation	5%
Proposal:	
Part 1: Research Pitch	5%
Part 2: Research Question	5%
Part 3: Introduction & Literature Review	5%
Part 4: First Draft	35%
Part 5: Review/Referee Report	10%
Part 6: Presentation	15%
Part 7: Final Draft	20%

Participation includes engagement in class discussion and demonstration of reading course material.

Grades will be updated throughout the semester on Canvas.

Grades will be based on the following scale:

Letter	% Range	Letter	% Range
A	[93,100]	C+	[77,80)
A-	[90,93)	C	[70,77)
B+	[87,90)	D	[60,70)
B	[83,87)	F	[0,60)
B-	[80,83)		

Principles of Community

The Principles of Community support the Colorado State University mission and vision of access, research, teaching, service and engagement. A collaborative, and vibrant community is a foundation for learning, critical inquiry, and discovery. Therefore, each member of the CSU community has a responsibility to uphold these principles when engaging with one another and acting on behalf of the University.

- **Inclusion:** We create and nurture inclusive environments and welcome, value and affirm all members of our community, including their various identities, skills, ideas, talents, and contributions.
- **Integrity:** We are accountable for our actions and will act ethically and honestly in all our interactions.
- **Respect:** We honor the inherent dignity of all people within an environment where we are committed to freedom of expression, critical discourse, and the advancement of knowledge.
- **Service:** We are responsible, individually and collectively, to give of our time, talents, and resources to promote the well-being of each other and the development of our local, regional, and global communities.
- **Social Justice:** We have the right to be treated and the responsibility to treat others with fairness and equity, the duty to challenge prejudice, and to uphold the laws, policies and procedures that promote justice in all respects.

Need Help? Rams Take Care of Rams

CSU is a community that cares for you. If you are struggling with drugs or alcohol and/or experiencing depression, anxiety, overwhelming stress or thoughts of hurting yourself or others please know there is help available. Counseling Services has trained professionals who can help. Contact 970.491.6053 or go to <http://health.colostate.edu>. If you are concerned about a friend or peer, tell someone by calling 970.491.1350 (or visit <http://safety.colostate.edu/tell-someone.aspx>) to discuss your concerns with a professional who can discreetly connect the distressed individual with the proper resources. Rams take care of Rams. Reach out and ask for help if you or someone you know is having a difficult time.

Title IX: Sexual Assault, Sexual Violence, Sexual Harassment:

CSU's Discrimination, Harassment, Sexual Harassment, Sexual Misconduct, Domestic Violence, Dating Violence, Stalking, and Retaliation policy designates faculty and employees of the University as "Responsible Employees." This designation is consistent with federal law and guidance, and requires faculty to report information regarding students who may have experienced any form of sexual harassment, sexual misconduct, relationship violence, stalking or retaliation. This includes information shared with faculty in person, electronic communications or in class assignments. As "Responsible Employees," faculty may refer students to campus resources (see below), together with informing the Office of Support and Safety Assessment to help ensure student safety and welfare. Information regarding sexual harassment, sexual misconduct, relationship violence, stalking and retaliation is treated with the greatest degree of confidentiality possible while also ensuring student and campus safety.

Any student who may be the victim of sexual harassment, sexual misconduct, relationship violence, stalking or retaliation is encouraged to report to CSU through one or more of the following resources: -Emergency Response 911 -Deputy Title IX Coordinator/Office of Support and Safety Assessment (970) 491-1350 - Colorado State University Police Department (non-emergency) (970) 491-6425

Please Visit: <http://oeo.colostate.edu/title-ix-sexual-assault> for more information.

Academic Integrity Academic misconduct (see examples below) undermines the educational experience at Colorado State University, lowers morale by engendering a skeptical attitude about the quality of education, and negatively affects the relationship between students and faculty/instructors.

Faculty/Instructors are expected to use reasonably practical means of preventing and detecting academic misconduct. Any student found responsible for having engaged in academic misconduct will be subject to academic penalty and/or University disciplinary action.

Students are encouraged to positively impact the academic integrity culture of CSU by reporting incidents of academic misconduct.

Examples of academic misconduct include (but are not limited to):

1. **Cheating** - Cheating includes using unauthorized sources of information and providing or receiving unauthorized assistance on any form of academic work or engaging in any behavior specifically prohibited by the instructor in the course syllabus or class presentation.
2. **Plagiarism** - Plagiarism includes the copying of language, structure, images, ideas, or thoughts of another, and representing them as one's own without proper acknowledgment, and is related only to work submitted for credit. Also included is the failure to cite sources properly; sources must always be appropriately referenced, whether the source is printed, electronic or spoken.
3. **Unauthorized Possession or Disposition of Academic Materials** - Unauthorized possession or disposition of academic materials includes the unauthorized selling or purchasing of examinations, term papers, or other academic work; stealing another student's work; and using information from or possessing exams that an instructor did not authorize for release to students.
4. **Falsification** - Falsification encompasses any untruth, either verbal or written, in one's academic work.
5. **Facilitation of any act of Academic Misconduct** - Facilitation of any act of academic misconduct includes knowingly assisting another to commit an act of misconduct.

"Plagiarism includes the copying of language, structure, ideas, or thoughts of another, and representing them as one's own without proper acknowledgment. Examples include a submission of purchased research papers as one's own work; paraphrasing and/or quoting material without properly documenting the source" (CSU Policies and Guiding Principles, 2017-2018).

Our motivation for rigorously enforcing a no-plagiarism policy is twofold: First, plagiarism is a form of theft. Taking someone else's words or ideas without attribution is stealing someone else's work. Second, copying someone else's work does not fulfill the purpose of the assignment, which is for you to develop critical thinking and analysis skills. You demonstrate this by presenting your own, new, synthesis and analysis in your writing. Simply copying or paraphrasing from source materials does not demonstrate this, however insightful the source(s) may be. Good writing generates new knowledge. This should be your goal in this class, in other courses at CSU, and in your career after you leave here.

In this course, all written work will be spot checked for plagiarism issues by both instructors and originality checking software such as VeriCite. If you are caught plagiarizing materials, you will receive a 0 for the assignment/exam/project, and depending upon the severity of the offense, an F in the course. All examples of plagiarism or academic dishonesty and will be reported to the Office of Conflict Resolution and Student Conduct Services for additional disciplinary action as outlined in the student handbook under the heading "academic integrity/Misconduct" <http://catalog.colostate.edu/general-catalog/policies/students-responsibilities/>.

AI Tools Policy

AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT) are powerful tools, and learning to use them is valuable. You are welcome to use AI tools to help you analyze data, write code, and understand concepts. However, your written submissions are expected to be entirely your work.

Tentative* Schedule of Classes for AREC570: Research Methods

	Topic	Tuesday	Thursday	Assignment
Week 1	Intro, What is Economic Research, Scientific Approach	8/25/2026	8/27/2026	
		Class Intro + Syllabus	What is Economic Research & the Scientific Approach	
Week 2	Methodological Foundations	9/1/2026	9/3/2026	
		Methodological Foundations	Methodological Foundations	
Week 3	Defining a Research Problem/Question	9/8/2026	9/10/2026	
		Defining a Research Problem/Question	Finding an idea	
Week 4	Planning a Research Project	9/15/2026	9/17/2026	
		Planning the research project	2-min Research Idea Pitch	Project Part 1: Research Idea & Pitch
Week 5	Writing the Introduction and Literature Review	9/22/2026	9/24/2026	
		Evaluate Pitch Presentations	Research Efficiency: reading and organizing the literature	Project Part 2: Research Question
Week 6	Literature Review/Writing Skills	9/29/2026	10/1/2026	
		Writing the Introduction and Literature Review	Literature Review/Writing Skills	
Week 7	Conceptual Framework	10/6/2026	10/8/2026	
		Conceptual Framework (Theory)	Conceptual Framework (Theory): Reporting	
Week 8	Data: Collection	10/13/2026	10/15/2026	
		Data: Collecting data	Data: Collecting data	Project Part 3: Intro and Lit Review
Week 9	Data: Managing Data for Reproducibility	10/20/2026	10/22/2026	

		Data: Managing Data for Reproducibility	Data: Managing Data for Reproducibility	
Week 10	Data: Reporting	10/27/2026	10/29/2026	
		Data: Reporting	Methods of Analysis: Econometric Models	
Week 11	Methods of Analysis: Econometric Models	11/3/2026	11/5/2026	
		Methods of Analysis: Econometric Models	Methods of Analysis: Econometric Models	
Week 12	Methods of Analysis: Qualitative and Mixed Methods	11/10/2026	11/12/2026	
		Methods of Analysis: Qualitative and Mixed Methods	Methods of Analysis: Qualitative and Mixed Methods	Project Part 4: First Draft
Week 13	Reviewing, Response to Reviewers	11/17/2026	11/19/2026	
		Reviewing	Response to Reviewers	
Thanksgiving		11/24/2026	11/26/2026	
		No Class	No Class	
Week 14	Results and Conclusions	12/1/2026	12/3/2026	
		Results and Conclusions	Research Presentation/Seminar + Ethics in Research	Project Part 5: Review
Week 15	Research Presentations	12/8/2026	12/10/2026	
		7-minute Presentations + 5-min for questions	7-minute Presentations + 5-min for questions	Project Part 6: Presentation
Finals Week:		12/15/2026	12/17/2026	
				Project Part 7: Final Draft

Last updated: August 13, 2026

**Please note that the instructor reserves the right to change or alter the course schedule. Dr. Countryman teaches one half of the content and Dr. Chenarides teaches the other half; they will switch midway through the semester.*